SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #38 · CHURCH CULTURE AND EXPECTATIONS

“If I doubt, I'm a bad Christian.”

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Where it often comes from

Many were taught that questions are sinful and faith means never wondering. Seasons of loss, unanswered prayer, or hard questions then bring fear and shame. People hide doubts and feel alone.

What Scripture teaches

A father cried out to Jesus, “I do believe; help my unbelief!” and Jesus healed his son. Jude writes, “have mercy on those who doubt.” The Bereans “examined the Scriptures every day to see if these teachings were true,” and Luke calls them noble-minded. Hebrews says, “faith is the assurance of what we hope for and the certainty of what we do not see.” Doubt can be a doorway to deeper faith when we bring it to God and to Scripture instead of hiding it.

> *“Immediately the boy’s father cried out, ‘I do believe; help my unbelief!’”* (Mark 9:24).

Also see

> “And indeed, have mercy on those who doubt” (Jude 1:22).

> “Now the Bereans were more noble-minded than the Thessalonians, for they received the message with great eagerness and examined the Scriptures every day to see if these teachings were true” (Acts 17:11).

> “Now faith is the assurance of what we hope for and the certainty of what we do not see” (Hebrews 11:1).

> “Why are you downcast, O my soul? Why the unease within me? Put your hope in God, for I will yet praise Him for the salvation of His presence” (Psalm 42:5).

Common self-statements

- Real believers never doubt.
- My questions prove I do not believe.
- God is angry at my doubts.
- I cannot tell anyone.
- I am losing my faith.
- I should not ask.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I either have perfect faith or none.
- Mind reading: Assuming others would condemn my questions.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling uncertain and concluding that my faith is gone.
- Fortune telling: Predicting I will lose my faith.

Challenging questions

- What am I doubting, specifically?
- How did Jesus respond to the father who admitted unbelief?
- Who in Scripture asked hard questions of God?
- What could I do to look for answers instead of hiding?

- Who could I talk with who welcomes honest questions?
- What do I still hold on to?

Truth summary

> Honest doubt brought to God is not a failure of faith. Jesus welcomes "I believe; help my unbelief." I can ask questions, seek answers, and keep trusting.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Faith
- Doubt
- Trust
- God, All Loving
- Wisdom

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Divorce
- Forgive/Forgiveness

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

Truth Be Told — Matthew West featuring Carly Pearce
Honesty about struggles makes room for grace and support instead of pretending to be fine.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If I doubt, I'm a bad Christian"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If I doubt, I'm a bad Christian." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What do I doubt?
- ☐ How did Jesus respond?
- ☐ Who asked hard questions?
- ☐ Where can I look?
- ☐ Whom can I ask?
- ☐ What do I still hold?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Jesus welcomes honest doubt.
- ☐ God has mercy on those who doubt.
- ☐ Examining Scripture is noble.
- ☐ Faith can grow through questions.
- ☐ I can bring my questions to God.
- ☐ I am not alone in doubt.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Mark 9:24
  "Immediately the boy's father cried out, 'I do believe; help my unbelief!'"
- ☐ Jude 1:22
  "And indeed, have mercy on those who doubt."
- ☐ Acts 17:11
  "Now the Bereans were more noble-minded than the Thessalonians, for they received the message with great eagerness and examined the Scriptures every day to see if these teachings were true."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Questions brought to God: Each week, write one question and where you looked for an answer.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Mark 9:24 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I believe; help my unbelief.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Faith" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Name the doubt. Write it in one sentence.
- [ ] Pray Mark 9:24. Say it honestly.
- [ ] Study. Look up the question in Scripture or with a trusted pastor.
- [ ] Talk to someone. Share it with a wise believer.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I doubt, I'm a bad Christian": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Questions brought to God
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I doubt, I'm a bad Christian.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I believe; help my unbelief. Thank You for welcoming my questions. Lead me to answers and keep me close to You. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.